NATIONAL HERALD ON SUNDAY
www.nationalheraldindia.com
17 DECEMBER 2017

Living with the dead

It is not easy to be surrounded by death all the time. Mashqoor Rashid's family has been living and managing Delhi's oldest cemetry on Bahadur Shah Zafar Marg for over 90 years

Photo: **Pramod Pushkarna**

MASHQOOR RASHID

I manage the *jadid qabristan* (new cemetery) on the Bahadur Shah Zafar Marg, which is known to be the oldest and one of the largest Muslim cemetery(ies) in Delhi. I am 70, and I have been working here for 45 years, having taken over from my father, Masood Ahmed, when I was 25.

The cemetery is over a hundred years old. The land here is owned by a private trust and was allotted by the British colonial authorities to the family who used to manage this place before my father took over. So, our family has been living on this property for 90 years now. Yes, our family home and the office are located here itself, which is convenient since this is a round-the-clock job.

After graduating with a Bachelor of Arts degree from Delhi University, I didn't want to take up this job. But my father's deteriorating health and my brothers' reluctance to manage the graveyard meant that I was pushed into this profession. First few days into the job, I was worried while signing receipts but then, gradually, over time, I got accustomed.

My job here is to collect money and sign receipts from the bereaved families who come looking for a burial spot. Besides, I also manage the staff, comprising four diggers, two guards and gardeners and a waterman. We charge ₹1,500 for a grave and ₹2,500 for the burial service. When I had just started out at this job, we didn't get more than 15-20 burial requests a day. Nowadays, there are times when there are 200-250 new burials happening. Despite the business picking up, we just manage to break even.

Most of the earnings go into paying the bills, salaries and running my family. I don't save much at the end of each calendar months. I have two sons, 25 and 24, and two girls, 22 and 21. The elder of both my boys and girls are married.

> **I wouldn't say that I enjoy my profession, but, at 70, there is nothing else I could think of doing better**

While I am in the vicinity of dead bodies at all times, I still squirm at the sight of one. It has been like this all along. So, it is mostly my staff who handles the dead whenever they are brought in. I wouldn't say that I enjoy my profession, but, at 70, there is nothing else I could think of doing better. Neither of my sons want to follow in my footsteps and run this place, which is completely fine with me.

A reason that this cemetery has survived the assault of privatisation is that it is not owned by any of the Waqf Boards. The other cemeteries in Delhi, like the one that was located where the Millennium Park now stands, was sold to the government by the Waqf Board.

I have lost count of the number of graves we have in this cemetery. Sometimes, it gets difficult to locate the grave of a person whose family member may be visiting to pay their obeisance to the deceased. In many cases, we are asked to dig out graves so that a member of the same family could bury another of their loved ones. There is already shortage of space for burial in Delhi.

A good thing about our cemetery is that Muslims from all sects, be it Sunni or Shia, can bury their loves ones here. We don't discriminate at all. The same is not the case with other cemeteries in Delhi.

(As told to Dhairya Maheshwari)

No country for disabled

APOORV OM

This is not a country for the physically-disabled. There are, of course, laws in place, but in reality, it exists only in court rooms and on paper. My father, who is a lawyer, has had to file cases for me. The system here doesn't support people like us. I am deaf, suffer from retinitis pigmentosa, a disorder of the eyes, which causes a gradual loss of vision. My speech is impaired, but I have undergone speech therapy. So, people around me can understand what I say, but maybe not everyone.

I am currently studying B. Arch at the School of Planning and Architecture, but I may have to leave it soon. I am 23-years-old and I should have been in the third year in college, but I'm still in the first year. I had to take a gap year in between because I had fallen ill, and the college authorities have persistently been against me. There was a project work in Jaipur, but I wasn't allowed to go with the students. The college authorities informed us that they didn't have anyone to go with me.

I have got a 50 per cent scholarship to Morrisville State University of New York. But, even then, if my parents have to fund the rest of it, they have to sell our ancestral property.

I completed my schooling from Navy Children's School. It was a regular school and after that my troubles to pursue education began. I could not give the IIT-JEE mains that year because I was in hospital for a lung surgery on the examination date. My lungs had cracked. I used to swim earlier, now I am not allowed to and I can't exert myself either.

Apoorv Om gifts a 2D model of the UNESCO building created by him to director general Irina Bokova in Paris.

By the time I was released from the hospital, most entrance exams were over; the only one remaining was the DU-CIC exam. I cleared the exam, but they refused to admit me. I had applied to Ram Lal Anand College and got admission into the Geoplogy department. I wasn't really interested in it; building design and construction is what I like.

In 2015, I wrote the IIT-JEE exams and was ranked 77. The authorities at the School of Planning and Architecture were not willing to admit me, then my parents approached the court. The college had to admit me, but they called my parents to ask them to withdraw my application. They said that they haven't tutored any physically-disabled children. According to the law, there should be a special educator and counsellor in every college to assist students like me, but the School of Planning and Architecture doesn't have it.

> **The School of Planning and Architecture was not willing to admit me, then my parents went to court. They had to admit me**

It is not easy to keep up one's spirits in such an atmosphere. It is depressing. There are days when I lose my will to live. There is no state support; my parents have been struggling to ensure I am educated. I have been told that I could probably hear if I have a cochlear implant surgery, but it costs ₹29 lakh. It is not affordable.

I am a UNESCO (United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organisation) Youth Volunteer and I have been requesting world body to pay more attention to the differently abled. Initially, I wrote to the Union HRD ministry for two years, but they never responded and then I started writing to the UN and they responded. I was a guest of the International Court of Justice in April 2016. My 2D model of the UNESCO headquarters has been installed at their office in Paris; I had presented it to the Director General of UNESCO in Paris. I began to use my sketching skills to get people to notice me. I have presented portraits to the vice president Venkaiah Naidu, former secretary general of the UN, Ban Ki-moon and Dalveer Bhandari, the Indian judge at the International Court of Justice, among others.

Once, I was back, I fell ill for a few months. I had to be admitted in the hospital because of infections and because of that I had to miss a year in college. Eventually, when I went back, they were not receptive to my needs. They even asked my mother to attend the classes with me so that she could be my tutor, but after a month, I refused it. I don't think my mother should come with me to college. How can I ever be a regular student then? They wouldn't respect my mother either. She would request them for written material, but they wouldn't oblige.

During one of my UN events in Delhi, we had requested the UN HRD Minister Prakash Javadekar to assist us; he had ensured that he would enable my studies at IIT. I am being awarded the National Gaurav Award at Vigyan Bhavan later this month and after that I hope to meet him. If he helps me with my admission at IIT, then it will be great, otherwise I will have to opt to study abroad.

(As told to Ashlin Mathew)

President of India Ram Nath Kovind presented the Empowerment of Persons with Disabilities 2017 award to Apoorv Om on December 3.

The healer

Illustration: **Abira**

VENUGOPAL MENON

Nothing under a hundred kilograms. That was what he was. He squatted on the floor legs tucked under his ample haunches, his mustache quivering in anticipation of the act of benevolence he was about to bestow: to diagnose, to plan and to heal forever, broken bones. About a dozen of us waited in the "repair" queue with our concerned families and friends in attendance to witness ancient wisdom at work.

The mystery of the cure they said lay in the leaves of which a paste was concocted that would be applied to the flesh around fractures. Folklore had it that the leaves were discovered by an ancestor of the family the squatting humanoid belonged to on a trip to the jungles to hunt deer. Having found and killed his quarry, the hunter ancestor had sliced the meat and chopped up the bones and wrapped them in leaves he had found handy in a bush nearby. On his return to the spot where he had stowed the meat he found that the slices of meat and the bones in it had completely fused without any trace of his knife work. This was the tale of serendipity of the miraculous cure that spread around the small town. The secret was handed down through generations several of whom thrived on the power of the magic leaf.

The case in point was the setting of a broken femur or the thigh bone that had been messed up by a non-orthopedic doctor in an Emergency Room in the local hospital. The technique here was simple and forthright. The patient is carried in by four persons, laid on his good side on the floor before the human hill squatting in wait to heal. Two of the attendants are asked to pull the broken leg by the ankle and a sheet of cloth is twisted and drawn between the legs of the victim like an exaggerated thong to be used as a tackle; the other two attendants hold the two ends of the thong and pull each to his side. And lo and behold, the broken leg stretches, the toes and feet of both the legs are now almost even with only a couple of inches more needed to be on exact level with each other. This is when the humanoid rises, balances his erect body on a knotted rope hanging from the ceiling and raises one leg to place the foot on the exact point where the femur snapped. With one heave he puts his weight on the spot raising the other leg off the floor to get the total benefit of his whole body weight and shouts for a report of alignment from the Feet End. A couple of more heaves and his attendants report the lengths of both feet are now symmetrically even.

> **The mystery of the cure they said lay in the leaves of which a paste was concocted**

The first part over, the healer resumes his squat on the floor beside the forged form.

Whoever mentioned anesthesia?

Now comes the leafy part. Goliath squats again, smears the green leafy paste around the broken thigh of the patient and places bamboo splints all around it and binds them with white cloth to secure the alignment until such time the leaves complete their action. Post-op advice for accompanying family: no more X-rays of the bone; bring the patient back after a week to check the progress of the healing.

Months later when I decided to have my fixed leg unfixed an X-ray revealed the broken ends of the bone had cracked longitudinally and had fused in a scissor joint at the edges. In an inevitable next step orthopedic surgery followed and the renowned surgeon after the surgery said to his patient whose fracture was now perfectly tended to, "Whatever pill you have been taking caused such a fusion of the bone ends, it took all my skills and extra hours of sawing to take them apart".

The leaves in the jungle!